COMPREHENSIVE GUIDES

Interview Guide

How to succeed in an English job interview

Before | During | After

Prepared for HUFLIT students

A step-by-step guide with practical tips, sample answers, and checklists.

Introduction

An English job interview tests more than your language skills. Employers want to see that you understand the role, communicate clearly, and can work well with others. The good news: interview success is mostly about **preparation**, and every step can be practiced. This guide walks you through the whole process in three stages and ends with special advice for HUFLIT students.

The process at a glance

1 BEFORE the interview

- Research the company and the role
- Prepare your stories and answers
- Get documents and logistics ready
- Practice out loud

2 DURING the interview

- Make a strong first impression
- Answer with clear structure
- Show positive body language
- Ask smart questions

3 AFTER the interview

- Send a thank-you email
- Follow up politely
- Reflect and improve
- Respond to the outcome

Common interview formats

Format	What to expect	Quick tip
Phone / video screening	10-30 minutes with HR. Basic questions about your CV, availability, and motivation.	Test your tech first. Smile; it changes your voice.
One-on-one interview	A manager or recruiter asks about skills, experience, and fit.	Use specific examples, not general claims.
Panel interview	Two or more interviewers ask questions in turns.	Look at whoever asks, then include the others.
Group interview	Several candidates are assessed together on teamwork and leadership.	Listen, support others, and speak with purpose.
Test or task round	English test, case study, or technical task (common for IT roles).	Read instructions twice and manage your time.

Remember

Interviewers rarely expect perfect English. They look for **clarity, confidence, and honesty**. A simple, well-organized answer beats a long, complicated one.

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STAGE ONE

Before the Interview

Step 1: Research the company and the role

- **The company:** mission, products or services, customers, culture, and recent news (check the website, LinkedIn, and social media).
- **The job description:** underline the key skills and keywords. Prepare one example for each.
- **The interviewer:** if you know the name, look up their role on LinkedIn.

Step 2: Prepare your content

- List 3-4 **strengths** and 3-4 **achievements** that match the job.
- Prepare short stories using the **STAR method** (see the box in the next section).
- Write and practice your **self-introduction** (30-60 seconds): Name, Education, Skills, Career Goal.
- Prepare an honest answer about a **weakness** and how you are improving it.

Step 3: Prepare logistics

Area	What to do
Documents	Print 2-3 copies of your CV; bring ID, certificates (e.g., IELTS, TOEIC), portfolio or project samples, a notebook, and a pen.
Location	Check the route the day before. Plan to arrive **10-15 minutes early**, not earlier.
Online interview	Test camera, microphone, and internet. Choose a quiet place, a neutral background, and good lighting. Join 5 minutes early.
Dress code	Choose clean, neat, and professional clothes. When unsure, dress one level more formal than the company culture.

Step 4: Practice

- Answer common questions **out loud**, not only in your head.
- Record yourself on your phone. Check your speed, clarity, and eye contact.
- Do a mock interview with a friend, classmate, or teacher and ask for honest feedback.

Pre-interview checklist

- ☐ Researched the company and role
- ☐ Prepared 3-4 STAR stories
- ☐ Practiced my self-introduction
- ☐ Prepared 3 questions to ask
- ☐ CV copies and documents ready
- ☐ Route or tech tested
- ☐ Outfit chosen and ready
- ☐ Slept well the night before

STAGE TWO

2 During the Interview

Typical flow of an interview

Stage	What happens	What you should do
1. Arrival	Meet reception and the interviewer.	Be polite to everyone. Greet with a smile and a handshake if offered.
2. Warm-up	Small talk (weather, traffic).	Keep it light and positive.
3. Introduction	"Please introduce yourself."	Use Name, Education, Skills, Career Goal in under 1 minute.
4. Core questions	Experience, skills, motivation, situations.	Use structure (STAR) and give specific examples.
5. Your questions	"Do you have any questions for us?"	Always ask at least 2 thoughtful questions.
6. Closing	Next steps are explained.	Thank them, restate your interest, and shake hands.

Common questions and how to answer

Question	What they want to know	Tip
Tell me about yourself.	Are you relevant and clear?	Present, past, future in 45 seconds. Focus on the job.
Why do you want to work here?	Did you do research? Are you motivated?	Mention a specific thing about the company and link it to your goals.
What are your strengths?	Can you do the job?	Choose 2 strengths and prove each with a short example.
What is your weakness?	Are you self-aware and growing?	Give a real, small weakness plus how you are fixing it.
Describe a challenge you solved.	How do you think and act?	Use the STAR method.
Where do you see yourself in 5 years?	Are you committed and ambitious?	Show growth in this field and with this company.
Why should we hire you?	What value do you bring?	Connect 2-3 skills directly to their needs.

The STAR method

Situation	Task	Action	Result
Set the scene in one sentence.	What was your responsibility?	What exactly did *you* do?	What was the outcome? Use numbers if possible.

Sample STAR answer: "Tell me about a time you worked in a team."

"In my final-year project (Situation), our group of four had two weeks to build a mobile app. I was responsible for testing and documentation (Task). I created a bug-tracking sheet, tested every feature daily, and updated the team each morning (Action). As a result, we fixed 20 bugs before the deadline and received the highest score in our class (Result)."

Body language and voice

DO	AVOID
• Sit upright and lean in slightly	• Looking at your phone or the floor
• Keep natural eye contact	• Crossed arms and fidgeting
• Smile and nod when listening	• Memorized, robot-like answers
• Speak slowly and clearly	• Interrupting the interviewer
• Pause before answering to think	• Criticizing past employers or teachers

What if you do not understand a question?

This is normal. Stay calm and use polite phrases: *"Could you repeat the question, please?"* *"Do you mean...?"* *"Let me think for a moment."* Never pretend to understand.

Good questions to ask the interviewer

- What does a typical day look like in this role?
- How is success measured in the first three months?
- What training or development opportunities are available?
- What are the next steps in the hiring process?

Avoid asking about salary or holidays in the first interview unless the interviewer raises the topic.

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STAGE THREE

After the Interview

Your follow-up timeline

When	Action
Right after	Write down the questions asked, your answers, and any names. Note what went well and what to improve.
Within 24 hours	Send a short thank-you email to the interviewer or HR contact.
After the stated deadline	If you have heard nothing, send one polite follow-up email (usually after 5-7 working days).
While waiting	Continue applying and preparing. Do not stop your job search until you have an offer.

Thank-you email template

Subject: Thank you - [Position] Interview

Dear Mr./Ms. [Last name],

Thank you for taking the time to meet with me today about the [Position] role at [Company]. I enjoyed learning more about [something specific from the interview], and our conversation made me even more excited about the opportunity.

I believe my skills in [skill 1] and [skill 2] would allow me to contribute to your team. Please let me know if you need any additional information from me.

I look forward to hearing from you.

Kind regards,
[Your full name]
[Phone number] | [Email]

Follow-up email (when you have not heard back)

"Dear Ms. [Name], I hope you are well. I am writing to follow up on my interview for the [Position] role on [date]. I remain very interested in the position. Could you please share any update on the timeline? Thank you for your time."

Handling the outcome

If you receive an offer

- Say thank you and show enthusiasm.
- Ask for the offer in writing.
- Review salary, hours, contract length, and benefits.
- It is fine to ask for a day or two to decide.

If you are not selected

- Thank them for the opportunity.
- Politely ask for feedback.
- Review your notes and improve one skill.
- Stay in touch; new roles may open.

Self-reflection questions

- [ ] Which question was hardest, and why?
- [ ] Which answer was my strongest?
- [ ] Did I give specific examples?
- [ ] Did I ask good questions?
- [ ] What will I do differently next time?
- [ ] Which English phrases should I practice more?

SPECIAL SECTION

4 Key Notes for HUFLIT Students

As a HUFLIT student, you have strengths that employers value. These notes will help you present them well.

Turn your strengths into selling points

Your strength	How to show it in the interview
Language skills	Mention your English level, certificates, and any other languages. Give an example of using English in class projects, presentations, translation, or interpreting.
Technology skills	For IT roles, describe projects, tools, and programming languages you used. Explain your role and the result in simple English.
Cross-cultural awareness	Studying languages builds understanding of other cultures. Highlight this for international or multicultural workplaces.
Learning attitude	As a student, you may not have long experience. Show that you learn fast with a real example.

Build experience before you graduate

- Take **internships**, part-time jobs, and volunteer work, even small ones. They give you real stories to tell.
- Join **clubs, competitions, and projects** at HUFLIT and describe your role, not just the activity name.
- Attend **career events, job fairs, and workshops** organized by the university and partner companies.
- Ask lecturers and alumni for advice, mock interviews, or recommendations.
- Keep your **CV and LinkedIn profile** updated and consistent.

Common challenges and how to solve them

Challenge	Solution
Nervous when speaking English	Practice daily for 5-10 minutes. Record yourself. Start with short, simple sentences.
Short answers ("Yes" or "No")	Add a reason and an example: Answer, Reason, Example.
Memorized, robot-like answers	Memorize only the structure and key points. Speak naturally.
Too modest about achievements	Use confident but honest language: "I led...", "I improved...", "I completed...".
Saying "My English is not good"	Say instead: "I am continuously improving my English, and I practice every day."
Limited work experience	Use class projects, internships, and activities. Show skills, not only job titles.

Safety and professionalism

- **Beware of scams.** A real employer does not ask you to pay a fee to get an interview or a job. Verify the company's website, address, and contact details.
- Do not share sensitive personal information (bank details, passwords) before you have a confirmed offer.
- **Be punctual and reliable.** If you cannot attend, inform the company as early as possible and politely.
- Keep your social media professional. Many recruiters check it.
- Use a professional email address, such as firstname.lastname@...

7-day preparation plan

Day	Focus	Task
Day 7	Research	Study the company, the role, and the job description.
Day 6	Self-introduction	Write and practice your 45-second introduction.
Day 5	STAR stories	Prepare 3-4 stories: teamwork, challenge, leadership, learning.
Day 4	Common questions	Practice 8-10 common questions out loud.
Day 3	Mock interview	Practice with a friend or teacher. Collect feedback.
Day 2	Logistics	Prepare documents, outfit, route or tech setup, and questions to ask.
Day 1	Rest	Quick review, relax, and sleep well. Trust your preparation.

Useful English phrases

Situation	Phrases
Greeting	"Good morning. Thank you for having me." / "It's a pleasure to meet you."
Need time to think	"That's a great question. Let me think for a moment."
Giving an example	"For example, in my internship at..." / "One example is..."
Showing interest	"I'm very interested in this role because..."
Closing	"Thank you for your time. I look forward to hearing from you."

Final thought

Every interview, successful or not, is practice for the next one. Prepare well, stay honest, speak with confidence, and believe in what you can offer. **Good luck!**